

The Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry uses a range of scientific, intelligence and evidence-based information to set the measures for managing risks associated with arriving goods and cargo. This includes targeting containers that:

- pose greater biosecurity risks
- are from known high-risk pathways such as Country Action List (CAL) countries
- are from countries with seasonal or emerging pest risks
- are within Australia - depending on the location of the final delivery address.

We also conduct routine verification activities on arriving cargo and surveillance activities around wharf areas and empty container parks, to monitor for exotic insects and pests.

You can help the on-arrival clearance process of sea containers by ensuring:

- your container is free of biosecurity risk material
- you have the correct documentation
- your goods and any packing materials meet the department's import conditions. This includes determining whether you need an import permit before shipping goods to Australia. This information can be obtained from [BICON](#).

We target a range of high-risk pests and contaminants (such as soil) on imported sea containers and non-containerised (break bulk) goods.

Sea containers and breakbulk cargo from countries and ports identified as having high levels of contamination, or high-risk pests, are considered to be high-risk pathways. We refer to these as Country Action List (CAL) locations.

Sea containers and break bulk cargo that originate or arrive from these countries or ports, or that tranship through them, are called CAL cargo.

Due to the increased risk, all CAL cargo is subject to heightened biosecurity measures on arrival. This includes mandatory six-sided inspection of external surfaces, and the internal surfaces of empty containers, on wharf at the port of discharge before release.

Individual goods and commodities on or within, sea containers are subject to relevant individual biosecurity import conditions on arrival in Australia. Import conditions for goods arriving in Australia can be found on [BICON](#). It may include the need for further inspection.

We have a government to industry initiative known as the [Sea Container Hygiene System](#) (SCHS) to clean and treat containers at the port of loading. The SCHS gives us confidence that containers shipped from recognised facilities and load ports, arrive in Australia free from biosecurity concerns. It allows us to recognise compliant entities with reduced intervention on arrival. This ensures the timely release of cargo from the wharf and a reduction in associated costs.

All sea containers that will be unpacked in rural areas must undergo a Rural Tailgate inspection (RTG) at the port of discharge. The requirement for an inspection is based on [delivery postcode classifications](#).

A departmental officer can conduct a RTG at an approved metropolitan Approved Arrangement (AA) site and selected wharf locations. When class 14.4 AA conditions are met, an approved Biosecurity Industry Participant (BIP) can also conduct an RTG inspection at a metropolitan AA site.

During a RTG, a biosecurity officer or approved BIP will inspect all external surfaces, including the underside, of the container. They will then open the container doors and inspect the doors, seals, walls and floor area for signs of biosecurity risk material. This includes inspecting for animals, invertebrates, plant or animal material, soil and other contaminants.

The following exceptions require an external container inspection only:

- consignments containing dangerous goods
- consignments containing hard frozen goods
- returning Australian meat goods
- diplomatic consignments
- ISO tanks

Departmental rural tailgate inspection requirements

The initial inspection must be conducted on:

- a registered truck, with a registered skeletal trailer that allows good visibility under the container
- a registered truck, with a registered flatbed trailer with height-extended twist locks where the container is raised above the flatbed platform to allow for good visibility under the container
- a sea container inspection stand that complies with the specifications for [sea freight container inspection stands](#).

The AA site must have an approved container inspection stand and wash bay. This is in case external contamination on the container is detected. If detected, cleaning and reinspection are required. Re-inspection of the container can only be performed on the inspection stand.

We have implemented an approved arrangement, AA class 14.4 -Rural tailgate inspection. This arrangement is integrated with BICON, and approved arrangement class 19. Class 14.4 authorises the Biosecurity Industry Participant (BIP), operating either a class 1.1 or class 1.3 sea and air freight depot with approved class 4.3 wash bay facilities, to conduct the rural tailgate inspection on certain containers destined for unpack in a rural classified location.

The scope for eligible class 14.4 sea containers includes:

- Impediment free containers, or
- Containers where the commodity has been assessed and released on documentation by the department or by accredited persons (where currently permitted), or
- Containers with commodities requiring mandatory treatment prior to a rural tailgate inspection being performed.

OUT of scope for class 14.4 includes:

- Prefabricated office/accommodation units (built as or shipped in a sea cargo container). These goods will continue to be managed under the BICON [Prefabricated office, accommodation units and caravans](#) case. Where destined for a rural delivery, a departmental rural tailgate inspection will be required.
- Containers where the commodity requires an inspection prior to being released from biosecurity control.

Where contamination is found that is not permitted to be managed by BIPs, or where any biosecurity risks of concern is found within the container, it must be immediately reported to the department, as per the approved arrangement class 14.4 conditions.

Lodging under the approved arrangement class 19

Class 19 accredited persons can self-direct eligible sea containers for a rural tailgate inspection at an AA class 14.4 site, using one of two AA class 19.1 concern types:

- RUAA (internal and external rural tailgate inspection)
- REAA (external only rural tailgate inspection).

Further details are available in the [Requirements and conditions for approved arrangement class 19.1: non-commodity for containerised cargo clearance](#) policy.

Class 14.4 Industry support material

The class 14.4: Rural tailgate inspection informative text and Class 14.4: Rural tailgate inspection awareness video provide detailed information to assist class 14.4 BIPs comply with the conditions of their arrangement.

Support materials include:

- information on industry direction types
- identification and management of biosecurity risks with the container
- release of containers from biosecurity control
- reporting of inspection outcomes to the department.

Class 14.4: Rural tailgate inspection awareness video

Download

If you have difficulty accessing these files, [contact us](#) for help.

Dangerous and/or Hazardous Goods: External inspection Direction

If it is known or there is any indication that a container is carrying dangerous goods we will not require the BIP to perform an internal container inspection. An external only inspection direction must be sought and conducted.

The Container Inspection Record must reflect that the goods were identified as dangerous. This prevents delays in processing and ICS Clear status.

We define dangerous goods as consignments or goods which present a potential work health and safety risk such as:

- explosives
- gases
- flammable liquids
- flammable solids
- oxidising substances
- toxic and infections substances
- radioactive material
- corrosives
- other hazardous material.

Importers of dangerous goods will remain responsible for:

- providing evidence that acceptable packing and dunnage was used in the consignment
- advising us of any contamination or non-compliant packaging or evidence of pests found when unpacking the container/s.

Release from biosecurity and documentation requirements for Class 14.4

The release from biosecurity and documentation requirements for class 14.4 on inspected sea containers are different to those for a departmental performed inspection.

Class 14.4 BIPs are authorised to release containers from biosecurity control where the container is determined to be free of biosecurity risk material and a record of the release from biosecurity control has been created by the BIP to meet the conditions of their arrangement. The BIP record of release from biosecurity control forms the legislated legal document for release from biosecurity control under the Biosecurity Act 2015.

BIPs may allow the container to leave the biosecurity area and the approved arrangement site (even where a 'conditional clear' status still exists in the Integrated Cargo System). We do not issue a notice of release (final and release directive notice) for containers released from biosecurity control by a BIP approved for class 14.4. The record of release replaces this notice.

While BIPs are not required to provide the record of release to the importer or agent (broker) for the container, it is encouraged. Importers or their agents may seek a copy of the record of release from the

BIP for their own record keeping and assurance purposes. The transfer of this information between industry parties is subject to commercial arrangements and not regulated by AA class 14.4 conditions.

Once we receive the BIP's container inspection record information, the departmental entry is finalised, and the Integrated Cargo System (ICS) updated to show a 'clear' status.

Departmental Auditing

In AA class 14.4, the legislative 'release point' is the BIP's creation of a record of release from biosecurity control document. Auditors may ask BIPs for this document when assessing compliance activities. Departmental auditors are aware of the class requirements. They will not request a department-issued notice of release (final and release directive notice) for containers released under AA class 14.4.

Departmental auditors can verify BIP Container Inspection Record outcomes regardless of how they are submitted. They can use the biosecurity portal, PDF form or third-party app. Submissions reported via the biosecurity portal will be assessed against the status of 'submitted'.

Lodgement of inspection results

Class 14.4 BIPs can lodge container inspection outcomes using 1 of 3 different methods,

- the [Biosecurity Portal](#)
- the [Rural tailgate container inspection record PDF](#)
- Submission via a third party application.

The preferred method of lodgement is via the portal. It provides live verification of data being entered to immediately identify errors and reduce processing times. The portal also provides the BIP with a wholistic view of relevant class directions and status.

It is important BIPs do not submit container inspection information using more than one method. This will cause unnecessary delays in container inspection records being finalised and ICS status updated.

Further information and reference materials

- For operational assistance with class 14.4 directions contact the [Tailgate](#) team.
- Quick reference guides on using the Biosecurity portal, including lodgement of inspection results are available on our [biosecurity portal support](#) webpage.
- Information on class 14.4 conditions can be found on our [Approved Arrangements](#) webpage.

For questions regarding rural tailgate Inspections performed by us or a Biosecurity Industry Participant under Class 14.4 [contact Sea Cargo Policy](#).

Exporters and shippers should ensure that containers are cleaned internally and externally, and that the integrity of the containers is maintained during packing and transport.

Before shipping, particular attention should be given to the:

- bottom rails of containers
- inside of forklift pockets
- lock fittings (in and around)
- the underside and cross members
- the door seals
- the top of the container.

The [Container Transport Unit code](#) provides advice on the safe packing and transport of sea containers as well as phytosanitary measures. Annex 6 provides information on minimising the risk of recontamination. This includes measures to remove and manage biosecurity risk material.

Cross contamination can occur at any stage of the pathway where suitable measures are not in place to manage biosecurity risks.

The main types of contaminants found on surfaces of sea containers include:

- Insects – a range of insects can lodge themselves or build nests on shipping containers. This includes ants, wasps, bees, beetles, moths and spiders.
- Snails – exotic snails such as the giant African snail and other snail species.
- Animals – rodents, geckos and toads are the main vertebrates found in and on shipping containers.
- Animal matter – includes animal and bird faeces, bones, skin and hair.
- Plants – plants can grow on shipping containers if residual seed has been allowed to germinate with or without contaminating soil. Other plant matter includes leaves, plant pathogens and other plant material.
- Soil – soil and soil related contaminants - especially in forklift pockets, twist lock fittings and underside and cross members.
- Fungi – fungi and other airborne spores that can lodge and grow on any soil on container surfaces.

The [Biosecurity risk treatment guide](#) has information on our approved treatment options to address specific biosecurity risks.

Industry must be aware of seasonal measures and new and emerging requirements before shipping goods and cargo into Australia.

Brown marmorated stink bug (BMSB)

To manage the seasonal risk of BMSB (*Halyomorpha Halys*), we implement additional measures each year. These apply to targeted goods that are:

- manufactured in, or shipped from, target risk countries
- that have been shipped during the BMSB risk season
- loaded on vessels that berth, load or tranship from target risk countries within the same period.

Further information is available on the [BMSB Webpage](#).

Khapra Beetle

Khapra beetle (*Trogoderma granarium*) is a small but serious pest.

We are implementing actions to address the risk of khapra beetle entering Australia. These actions are being implemented in phases, and have changed import conditions for plant products and sea containers.

Further information is available on the [Urgent actions to protect against khapra beetle](#) webpage.

We undertake regular monitoring, surveillance and response measures, such as [Cargo Compliance Verification \(CCV\)](#) inspections, at and around wharf areas and empty container parks, for unwanted exotic pests.

We also work closely with state and territory agencies and industry during heightened biosecurity periods such as brown marmorated stink bug season or where post-border detections have been identified.

Goods arriving in Australia can often be cleared by us using declarations and information provided by the importer. To decrease the likelihood that your goods will need to be opened and inspected, provide all required documents that need to accompany your goods as specified in [BICON](#).

We will issue the importer with a directive that goods are released from biosecurity control or if any actions are required such as:

- inspection
- treatment
- isolation
- hold pending further information or insect identification.

For further information on our approach to imported cargo is on the [Imported Cargo Compliance](#) factsheet or on the [Clearance and inspection](#) webpage.

It is important that biosecurity incidents are reported as soon as practicable to limit the risk associated with any pest or disease entering, establishing or spreading into Australian territory.

You are required by law to report certain biosecurity incidents if you are:

- a person in charge of goods subject to biosecurity control, or an exposed good order
- a person in charge of an aircraft or vessel carrying goods subject to biosecurity control, or an exposed goods order
- you become aware of a reportable biosecurity incident in relation to those goods.

A report can be made by calling 1800 798 636 or by completing the [Reportable Biosecurity Incident form](#).

See.Secure.Report

If you see a biosecurity risk that you think may have hitchhiked to Australia, secure the goods to limit the movement where possible, and immediately report it to the department on 1800 798 636 or [complete the online form](#).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/import/arrival>